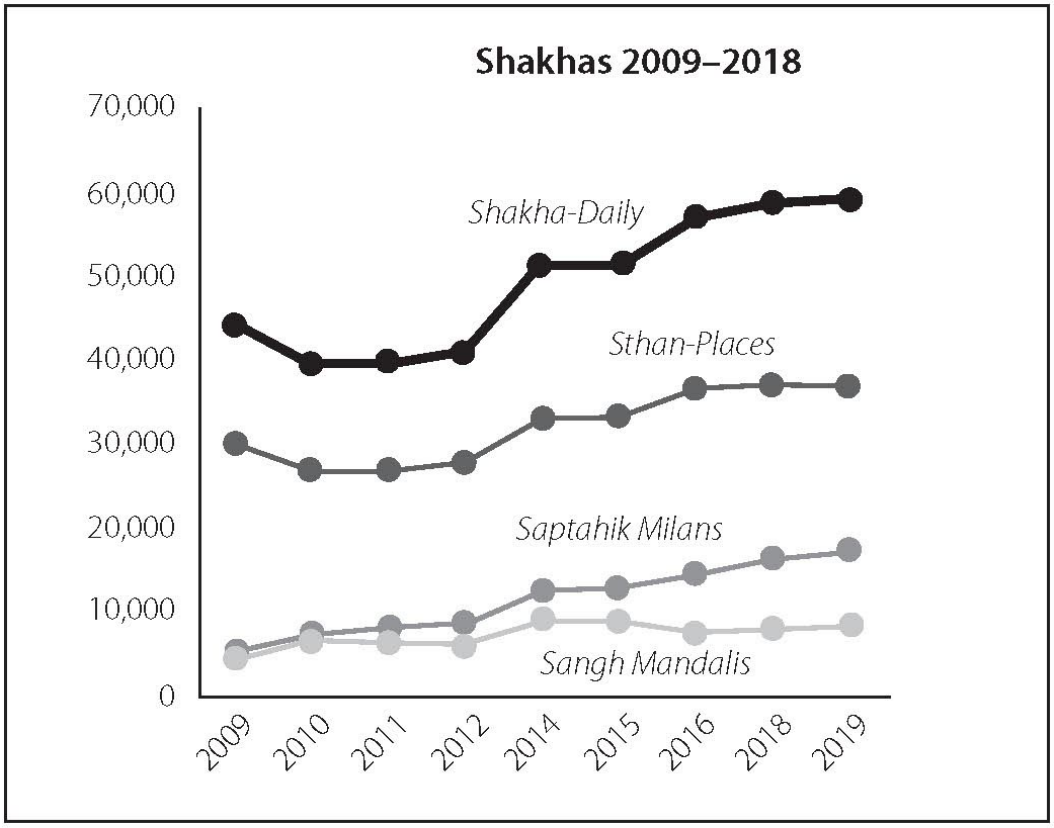
RSS data shows that the number of daily shakhas saw a spurt after the first Modi government came to power in 2014. As one RSS leader in UP told me, 'We are growing fast but we are also very conscious that some of the new people who come to us may be coming only because they may have an impression that they could somehow get closer to power through the Sangh. Our biggest challenge is to keep estimating who is joining us because of such perceptions and who is genuine. We are only interested in people who genuinely believe in our thinking.'[17]

Figure 12.2: Annual Growth of RSS Daily Shakhas, Saptahik Milans, Monthly Mandalis and Places Where Shakhas are Held (2009–2018)



Source: RSS Annual Reports
Note: Membership information for 2013 not available.

Anyone who knows the Sangh knows that 'shakhas' (literally, branches), or daily gatherings—at the bottom of the RSS organisational pyramid—are its lifeblood.[18] They were set up by RSS